Resilience replaces labels in sustainable finance

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【メール原文】

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Responsible investors will increasingly judge assets on their contribution to resilience, security, and financial outcomes rather than on sustainability labels.
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Asia and Europe are likely to adopt different approaches to sustainable finance requirements, with Asia favoring pragmatism and flexibility while Europe maintains a more prescriptive and stringent model.
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Investors and issuers that connect climate, security, and geopolitics to measurable risk-management frameworks and identify related strategic opportunities will be better positioned financially as global fragmentation continues.

Eurasia Group has issued 54 trajectory assessments across 36 tracked trends since the first quarterly publication of Responsible Investing: Now, Next, Later. Over the course of the full year since the first report 29 trends accelerated, 6 held steady, and 1 slowed. In the first report (September 2025), biodiversity showed strong momentum as a cross-cutting theme, but other emerging topics overshadowed it as the year went on. Water security rose consistently. Security and defense gained momentum on the back of world events, while social themes lost ground. Overall, sustainable finance evolved significantly, as resilience and security emerged as key objectives.

Looking back over the first year of the Responsible Investing series, five megatrends stand out.

Physical climate risk is becoming an immediate investment consideration. A succession of heatwaves, droughts, and wildfires, intensified by El Niño, exposed the limits of existing infrastructure, insurance models, and corporate planning. Understanding how climate hazards affect portfolios is increasingly part of financial risk management. Efforts are also underway to make resilience investment pay off more clearly, including by making insurance the key lever in adaptation financing.

Resilience is emerging as a broader framing for sustainable investing. Sustainable investing is shifting away from labels such as ‘ESG’ and ‘Net Zero’ toward tangible outcomes, transition readiness, and financial materiality. Greenwashing concerns and political backlash, particularly in the US, have increased scrutiny of sustainability-labeled products, contributing to greenhushing (downplaying sustainability measures) and in some cases, removal of sustainability labels. Against this backdrop,

resilience is gaining traction as a broader, less politically charged framing of sustainability, emphasizing transition preparedness and the delivery of financial outcomes.

Adaptation, water, and nature are gradually becoming investable. Climate adaptation has grown from a niche segment into an expanding area of investment, with rising interest in resilience-focused financing, catastrophe bonds, and disaster risk-transfer mechanisms, alongside discussion of adaptation taxonomies. Momentum is also growing in Asia around biodiversity taxonomies. The People's Bank of China Biodiversity Finance Taxonomy covers 87 activities across four categories and requires financed activities to do no significant harm to ecosystems. The taxonomy is not yet final, but its criteria should help channel capital toward qualifying activities, and we expect other markets in the region to follow suit. Water security has also become a strategic priority for governments, issuers, and investors. Blue finance, which funds water infrastructure, desalination, wastewater treatment, and marine ecosystems, has grown as a category over the past year and increasingly attracts corporate issuers.

Regulators are making disclosure mandatory but less demanding. Sustainability disclosure is moving from voluntary commitments to enforceable market rules. However, by the time they come into force, requirements in many jurisdictions are less stringent than initially anticipated. California is a notable exception with its climate disclosure legislation (SB 253). In Europe, policymakers controversially sought to balance sustainability goals with competitiveness and growth by simplifying disclosure requirements and tightening oversight of ESG ratings providers. Globally, continued uptake of International Sustainability Standards Board (ISSB) frameworks made comparable investor-focused information more available. The ISSB's work on nature-related disclosures points toward a global baseline for nature risks, although disclosures will be voluntary at first.

Geopolitics is reshaping the rules of sustainable capital. As geopolitical fragmentation deepens, responsible investing increasingly reflects geopolitical priorities and regional regulatory preferences rather than moving toward global convergence. Views on defense investing have shifted toward supporting sovereign security, and investors and lenders largely updated their defense policies over the past year. Some questions remain on the treatment of controversial weapons and dual-use products.

Market perception will continue to diverge. The ESG backlash has pushed market participants to recenter their objectives around resilience and long-term value creation, which now underpin decision-making. Transition categorization has emerged to support those needs. Win-win opportunities that advance sustainability objectives as well as resilience and security—while also producing meaningful returns—are becoming the most prized.

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